

my ministry could have taken in an earlier department I ran, which would have helped a particular state in their local elections. I went to the PM seeking his guidance and permission to announce it and I said it will help the state government significantly... And he said, 'I don't want you to take decisions just because there is an election' and he didn't allow me to announce it, [despite] everything being ready. He allowed me to announce it after the state polls were over.

He doesn't believe that government works election to election... government works in the long term for the good of the nation. Similarly, we have balanced the interests of consumers and farmers. In our decisions related to the farm sector, because inflation has been brought under control due to the strong measures of both the government and the Reserve Bank of India... we are back to sub 4% inflation rates now for two months in a row. That has helped us to bring back import duties on palm oil, so we can encourage farmers to grow more soya bean and oilseeds and become self-sufficient in oilseeds, balancing the interests of low inflation for consumers and farmers' interests.

“Every Cabinet meeting makes game-changing strides towards our dream to make India a developed nation, with an intermediate milestone: in this term, it'll become the third-largest economy”

Similarly, we expect a good onion crop this year. The *kharif* season is starting and [these] crops cannot be stored... We have built buffer stock so that consumers can keep getting onions at affordable prices, [while]... we are going to look at how to export farmers' *kharif* crop so that they get high prices for onions. Similarly, we have had a bumper crop in rice; therefore, we have decided to remove the minimum export price of basmati rice and are reviewing other elements of export controls to make sure both farmers and consumers benefit from government policy. **It has nothing to do with elections—these are long-term policies. BT**

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progressing toward this goal with Prime Minister [Narendra] Modi's leadership during these 100 days.

AOK: The opposition claims that the Modi 3.0 government is taking the middle path on many issues. They point to your ministry's decision to introduce a Unified Pension Scheme, and changes to the capital gains tax as examples. What is your response?

A: These claims are completely wrong. **In the Budget, we always consult all stakeholders before making any changes, and if we feel a change is necessary, we bring it in without hesitation.** We've already had discussions on the pension issue with central government employees, and we will take a decision soon. This is not a U-turn. As for the capital gains tax, we consulted everyone and introduced a proposal in the Budget to treat all asset classes equally. We've brought back the option of indexation and given taxpayers the choice to either use the indexation method or the new scheme. It's up to the taxpayer to decide which option results in lower taxes. Offering options is not a U-turn; it's part of our system.

AOK: Sebi chief Madhabi Puri Buch is facing criticism from the opposition for alleged conflict of interest. Some Sebi officials have also reportedly complained against her. Do you think it's appropriate for her to continue in her role amidst these controversies?

A: The opposition is making baseless accusations without facts. Both the Sebi chief and her husband have responded to the allegations with facts. The opposition should responsibly analyse the situation instead of making such accusations.

AOK: Union Minister Nitin Gadkari wrote a letter on July 28, asking for the removal of the 18% GST on life and medical insurance. Additionally, there was an incident in Coimbatore where a hotelier asked you about GST, which went viral. Can you respond to these issues?

A: The issue of medical insurance is currently under study by a group of ministers, and their recommendations will be discussed in the GST Council meeting in November. As for the Coimbatore incident, it wasn't a private gathering; it was a consultation with various department heads and industry associations. We have taken their suggestions seriously and will discuss them in the GST Council. **BT**

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